

Identifying AI in Student Work

A practical reference for educators

The Process

*The best way to approach AI usage in student work is to foster a productive conversation. The only iron clad proof that a student used AI is if they admit that they did; this guide is intended to give you tools and a process to follow to have that conversation with a student you suspect of using AI. All of the following steps are intended to work in conjunction with each other to build a case; **none of them are an indication on their own that a student used AI.***

1. Something's Off

Start with your own expertise. You know your curriculum and your content. Pay attention when something in a student's work seems unusual, things like:

- A fact is incorrect.
- A quotation appears to be made up.
- Information doesn't match the text or material being discussed.
- The student's writing sounds noticeably different from their usual work.
- A writing or punctuation pattern appears that you have not seen from the student before.

2. Review AI-Detection Results

Use AI-detection tools (like Turnitin) as a data point.

Turnitin's AI-detection tools analyze characteristics of written text, including:

- Burstiness: the complexity and variation of sentence structure.
- Perplexity: characteristics of word choice and how expected those choices are.

Important

AI detectors can return **false positives**. Do not treat a detector result by itself as definitive proof that a student used AI.

3. Examine Document History

Word Online tracks changes made to a document. If you suspect AI use:

1. Ask the student to share the document with you.
2. Make sure you have **Edit Permission**.
3. Review the document's "Version History."
4. Look for unusual changes or large blocks of text appearing at once.

A large block of newly added text may indicate that material was pasted into the document rather than composed gradually.

4. Look for Writing Patterns

AI-generated writing can exhibit recurring patterns, including:

Parallel Structure

Sentences or clauses that mirror one another. For example:

It's not just __; it's __.

Not only does this __, it __.

It would appear that __, so we should __ instead.

Rule of Threes

AI frequently produces groups or lists of three ideas. For example:

The novel explores themes such as grief, mental health, and healing.

The movie uses dramatic lighting, rapid editing, and minimal dialogue to convey...

Unusual Punctuation

Pay attention when a student suddenly begins using punctuation they don't typically use.

For example:

- Semicolons
- Em dashes

A new punctuation habit may be an indicator when it represents a noticeable change from the student's established writing style.

Important Limitations

AI indicators are not proof by themselves

Students may naturally produce writing that resembles characteristics associated with AI-generated text. Consider the student's previous work and individual writing style before drawing conclusions.

Multilingual Learners

Work from multilingual learners can produce false positives in AI-detection systems. If an MLL student's work is flagged:

- Consider the student's language learning context.
- Consult appropriate support staff.
- Seek additional evidence before drawing conclusions.

Formulaic Writing

Some students naturally write in a formulaic style because that is how they have been taught. A student's voice or word choice may therefore resemble patterns commonly associated with LLM-generated writing. Consider whether the work is consistent with the student's established writing.

Discuss the Work With the Student

The goal is to understand what happened and give the student an opportunity to explain their work and process. Whenever possible, treat the conversation as a learning opportunity rather than immediately approaching it as a punitive interaction.

Talk with the student about:

- The work you are concerned about
- How they completed the assignment
- Their writing process
- Sources or evidence they used
- Any AI tools they used

If the Student Resists

If the student is resistant to the conversation:

1. Document your concerns.
2. Gather the evidence you collected and write a short summary of your findings.
3. Refer the matter to Administration when appropriate and follow district policy for Academic Dishonesty.

Sources & Further Reading

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